

Layer Effects

Learning Objectives

- Apply drop shadows and glows to layers
- Use layer masks for non-destructive editing
- Combine multiple layer effects for creative results

Engage (5-7 minutes)

When the sun shines behind a tree, the tree casts a shadow on the ground. Layer effects in GIMP add similar shadows, glows, and depth to your images. Today we learn how to make our digital artwork look three-dimensional and professional.

Explore (10-12 minutes)

Open an image with text or shapes on a separate layer. Right-click the layer and explore “Layer Effects” or “Filters > Light and Shadow.” Apply a drop shadow to your text. Adjust the shadow distance, blur, and color. Try adding an outer glow effect to a shape.

Explain (10-12 minutes)

Layer effects add visual depth and style to layers. Drop Shadow creates a shadow behind a layer, making it appear lifted. Outer Glow adds a colored aura around an object. Bevel and Emboss give a 3D raised appearance. Layer masks hide parts of a layer without permanently erasing them—paint black on the mask to hide, white to reveal.

Elaborate (8-10 minutes)

Think of decorating a school notice board. You pin papers (layers) and add borders, shadows, and highlights to make them stand out. Drop shadow is like the shadow a pinned paper casts on the board. Layer masks are like using removable tape—you can hide or reveal parts without cutting the paper. What effect would you add to a Diwali greeting card?

Evaluate (5-8 minutes)

Exit ticket: Name two layer effects and describe what each does. Then apply a drop shadow to text in GIMP. If you finish early, experiment with layer masks to blend two images together.